tank is tortoise-shaped; the second is square, with a wooden superstructure, affixed with fire torches, under which the people of the citadel perhaps bathed, lounged and entertained. A great fire will eventually burn down this superstructure, leaving heaps of ash to be discovered by archaeologists 1600 years later. Similar but humbler bathing tanks exist across the city.[9]

Stepping out of the eastern gate of the citadel, we see a memorial pillar to an army chief, Mahasenapati Chamtapula, inscribed with scenes glorifying his life. This is one of the at least twenty-two such limestone pillars we'll see in the city, indicating that raising memorial pillars for prominent people is common—usually, but not always, for kings, queens, nobles or warriors. Many pillars have battle scenes honouring warriors and their victories in war. On one such pillar, a horseman with a spear battles two foot soldiers, with many men lying dead around them. Scenes like this suggest that war is an ever-present threat and even a royal pursuit. However, not far from the citadel, we're relieved to see a pillar dedicated to the foreman of the artisans; another honours a king's mother.

To the south and east of the citadel are several religious buildings. Walking east, towards the Great Stupa of Vijayapuri, we pass a few of the more than thirty Buddhist establishments found in the city, representing at least four sects, split into two broad denominations: Hinayana and Mahayana. The sounds of debate and laughter fill the streets as monks and nuns go about their day. Their monasteries often feature a pillared hall in the centre, surrounded by a covered veranda and, on average, ten to fifteen rooms with terracotta-tiled roofs (about a quarter of the capacity of later monasteries at Nalanda). They have a central kitchen, dining hall and storerooms, and shared toilets with drains. The enrobed inhabitants lounge and chat, or amuse themselves with games played on boards etched into the stone floor, or toss ivory dice similar to those uncovered here. Newer monasteries, likely influenced by architectural fashions coming down from Gandhara (north-west Pakistan and northeast Afghanistan), have standing Buddha statues in apsidal shrines and adjoining stupas in brick and plaster, including one with a swastika design in brick inlay (now transplanted on Nagarjunakonda Island).